

4.2 Ring Tones

A ring tone is the sound made by a telephone to indicate an incoming call. The term is often used to refer to the customisable sounds available on mobile phones. The facility was originally provided just so people would be able to determine when their phone was ringing, when in the company of other mobile phone owners.

Most mobile phones today can use short clips of music or popular songs as ring tones, and the download and sale of these has become a major source of revenue for the mobile service providers as well as independent mobile content providers.

A phone only rings when a special “ring signal” is sent to it. For regular telephones, the ring signal is a 90-volt 20 Hz AC wave generated from the switch the telephone is connected to. For mobile phones, the ring signal is a specific radio-frequency signal. But a ringing phone can be intrusive at times—especially so in silent zones such as hospitals and classrooms. An alternative to a ring tone for mobile phones is a vibrating alert.

There are different types of ring tones depending on the sound played out. The three broad categories are Monophonic, Polyphonic and Music Ring Tones.

Monophonic: Early phones had the ability to play only monophonic ring tones, short tunes played with simple tones. These early phones also had the ability to have ring tones programmed into them using an internal ring tone composer. Various formats were developed to enable ring tones to be sent via SMS

